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REVIEW

WSJ

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL WEEKEND

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What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **Tesla won its fight** over a record-breaking pay package for Chief Executive Elon Musk that was approved by shareholders in 2018, ending the legal battle over his compensation that grew in value to total \$139 billion. **A1**

◆ **Major U.S. stock indexes** rose on Friday, with the S&P 500, Nasdaq and Dow industrials advancing 0.9%, 1.3% and 0.4%, respectively. **B9**

◆ **Home sales rose** in November for the third consecutive month, with lower mortgage rates injecting some fresh momentum into the housing market. **A2**

◆ **Economists warned** that uncertainty about the accuracy of inflation figures may linger in coming reports after November's numbers were clouded by sketchy data collection. **A2**

◆ **Universal Studios is in** early planning stages to build a new theme park in Saudi Arabia, setting up a potential rivalry with Disney in the booming Middle East market. **B9**

◆ **Sony will pay more** than \$450 million to double its stake in Peanuts Holdings, the owner of the cartoon characters created by Charles M. Schulz. **B9**

World-Wide

◆ **The U.S. military** conducted a large-scale attack against Islamic State targets in Syria as the Trump administration retaliated for the killing of three Americans. **A1**

◆ **The Justice Department** released a batch of files related to the government's investigation of Jeffrey Epstein, but lawmakers said the disclosure fell far short of what they had demanded. **A1**

◆ **Nine pharmaceutical** companies agreed to lower the prices that certain federal government programs and patients pay, in a new round of industry pacts with the Trump administration. **A3**

◆ **Trump ally Elise Stefanik** said she would drop out of the race for New York governor and wouldn't seek reelection to the House. **A3**

◆ **Staffers assigned** to the Pentagon from the cost-cutting agency formerly run by Elon Musk were put in charge of buying thousands of small drones for the military. **A5**

◆ **Europe chose not** to impound Russian assets to fund Ukraine's war effort, demonstrating an apparent lack of resolve, and instead approved a \$105 billion loan that puts EU taxpayers on the hook. **A7**

NOONAN

What was Susie Wiles thinking? **A13**

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In Year-End Q&A, Putin Tries to Rally Russians



HOME THEATER: A woman in St. Petersburg watched a TV broadcast of President Vladimir Putin's annual press conference on Friday. Putin used the event, which lasted 4½ hours, to try to bolster support for continuing the war in Ukraine. **A7**

DOJ Releases Batch of Epstein Files

The Justice Department has released a batch of files related to the government's investigation of Jeffrey Epstein, including images of former President Bill Clinton and other celebrities. Lawmakers said the disclosure fell far short of what they had demanded.

Congress voted overwhelmingly in November to mandate

By Khadeeja Safdar,
Joe Palazzolo
and C. Ryan Barber

the disclosure of records relating to Epstein and his associate Ghislaine Maxwell, including immunity deals and internal agency communications. The law passed over the initial objections of President Trump and

reversed a decision in July by Justice Department officials that further disclosure wasn't warranted.

Among the newly public materials were images of Clinton swimming in a pool with Maxwell and sitting on a plane with a woman whose face is redacted. A spokesman for the former president said Clinton had cut off ties long before

Epstein's crimes came to light. "They can release as many 20-plus-year-old photos as they want, but this isn't about Bill Clinton," spokesman Angel Urena said on X. "This is about shielding themselves from what comes next, or
Please turn to page A4

◆ **Scan code to see Epstein files released so far..... A4**

EXCHANGE



AI EXTRAVAGANZA
What 26,382 of the world's smartest minds really think about artificial intelligence. **B1**

Eagles Fan Gains Fame For Parodies

* * *
Army vet wows
NFL stars and
music legends

By XAVIER MARTINEZ

SEVERN, Md.—Robert Williams Jr. nearly jumps out of his chair toward the TV, where the Philadelphia Eagles are on the verge of breaking a losing streak. "I've got it!" he yells to nobody in particular. If this were any other American household, it would be reasonable to assume Williams is ecstatic over a bet, fantasy-football win or simply the Eagles' rout of the Las Vegas Raiders.

Instead, Williams is doing what he does most Sundays between September and January: recapping the game with
Please turn to page A6

Tesla Wins Fight Over Musk Pay

By BECKY PETERSON
AND THEO FRANCIS

Tesla won its fight over a record-breaking pay package for Chief Executive Elon Musk that was approved by shareholders in 2018, ending the yearslong legal battle over his compensation that grew in value to total \$139 billion.

In an opinion issued Friday, the Delaware Supreme Court said the lower court's ruling would have deprived Musk of

compensation for several years of work, and therefore he should get the full pay package.

The court's opinion reversed the 2024 decision from Delaware's Chancery Court to rescind Musk's pay package after finding that Tesla's directors were beholden to its CEO and that the approval process for the pay deal was tainted and lacked transparency.

"Because it is the unmaking of an agreement, rescission is an

Putin Backed Witkoff In His Unlikely Diplomatic Ascent

Release of American prisoner, Saudi foray bolstered Trump's 'dealmaker'

Steve Witkoff, a billionaire real-estate developer and longtime golfing partner of Donald Trump, was just days into his job as the new president's special en-

By Joe Parkinson,
Rebecca Ballhaus,
Drew Hinshaw,
Thomas Grove, Benoit
Faucon and Yaroslav
Trofimov

voy to the Middle East when he received a tantalizing message from the crown prince of Saudi Arabia.

Vladimir Putin was interested in meeting Witkoff—so interested that he might

consider releasing an American prisoner to him. The invitation came from a Kremlin moneyman named Kirill Dmitriev, using the de facto Saudi ruler, Mohammed bin Salman, as an intermediary.

There was just one thing: Witkoff would be expected to come alone, without any CIA handlers, diplomats or even an interpreter, a person familiar with the outreach said.

The Russian president had been studying psychological profiles of the officials around Trump, including Keith Kellogg, the retired three-star general
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U.S. Hits Syria to Avenge Deadly Ambush

Officials say dozens of sites struck after three Americans were killed in attack

The U.S. military conducted a large-scale attack against Islamic State targets in Syria as the Trump administration retaliated for the killing of three Americans.

By Michael R. Gordon,
Lara Seligman
and Jared Malsin

More than 70 targets were being struck by U.S. F-15E and A-10 warplanes, Apache attack helicopters and Himars rockets, a U.S. military official said Friday.

The operation is being dubbed "Hawkeye Strike" in honor of the Iowa National Guard soldiers who were killed and wounded in an assault the Trump administration has blamed on Islamic State.

The gunman who ambushed the U.S. soldiers was killed in the original attack. But President Trump on Sunday vowed to take military action against the group. The strikes were the biggest U.S. attack against Islamic State in Syria since the fall of former Syrian President Bashar al-Assad late last year.

"Because of ISIS's vicious killing of brave American Patriots in Syria...I am hereby announcing that the United States is inflicting very serious retaliation," Trump said in a post on Truth Social.

Jordan's F-16 fighters also were involved in the operation, according to U.S. officials. A spokeswoman for the Jordanian Embassy in Washington had no comment.

The strikes, which involved the delivery of more than 100 precision-guided munitions, were carried out in central Syria and targeted Islamic State infrastructure and weap-
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